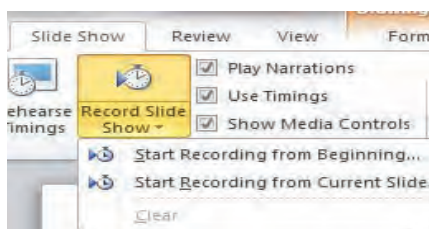


Banned in the US

Sale of Office with the DOCX extension was banned in the US last year, over a patent issue. Microsoft has now released a patch to fix it

Go free

If you're looking for a budget alternative to Excel, try Calc by OpenOffice, the most downloaded free office productivity suite

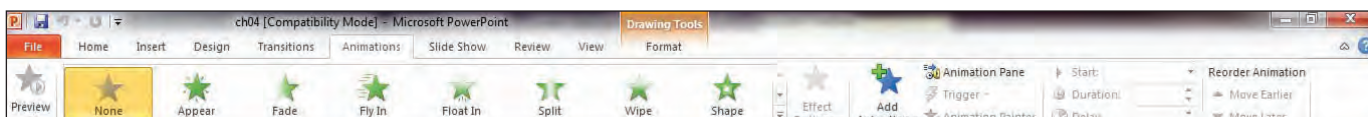


Recording a slideshow as a video

off in the task pane like in previous versions. With "Sparklines" that can be embedded in any worksheet, you can add instant visualisations to your data that give you a picture of what the numbers mean without creating a chart for every cell. You might take some time learning to exploit them, but these give you the kind of visualisations we're getting used to seeing in Web 2.0 apps inside your spread sheet.

Microsoft PowerPoint 2010

The most useful addition to PowerPoint



Quick Access toolbar

is the ability to broadcast a presentation online. Others can view it on their web browsers without having PowerPoint installed. There's a set of basic video editing tools built directly into PowerPoint 2010. You can now embed videos directly from online video-sharing sites such as YouTube. Although you can apply video styles to an online video, reflections, crops and rotations don't work.

You can now merge two presentations. PowerPoint 2010 is also a lot better at recovering unsaved files now, and you can recover previous versions of your current document and record your presentations as videos, a feature which was missing in both Office 2003 and Office 2007 and was continuously in demand.

OneNote 2010

OneNote is powered up and now boasts of a powerful "linked" notes feature that lets you work in any Word or PowerPoint document, or while viewing pages

in a browser, and create notes that are automatically linked to the document in the other application. It also finally gets the Ribbon interface, plus the advanced typographic features available in Word. Navigation through notebooks has also been improved. The search feature in OneNote has been augmented as well, as previously it was not particularly useful. You can now specify some advanced options as to whether to search on a page or in a section, group, individual notebook or all notebooks.

Earlier all the clipped information from web browsers, snapshots of the screen and the results of "Send to OneNote" used to go under the Unfiled Notes section, but now you can now pick which section to put that information in. You can even put multiple clips on the same page.

OneNote 2010 also makes it extremely easy to share notebooks and collaborate with other people in them. They can work in the same page; even at the same time if

necessary. Whatever they add is highlighted and marked with their initials to remove confusion. There are a host of other small improvements like editing equations, and translation tools which work across multiple languages. OneNote 2010 also has excellent ink support.

Office Web Apps

The final major feature in the Office 2010 is the addition of Office Web Apps. Office Word App lets you create, edit, and save Word documents. Office PowerPoint App lets you create and edit presentations from the web. You can even pick themes and slide layouts. You can also insert animations, pictures, charts, and tables into existing PowerPoint presentations. Office Excel web application allows you to create, edit and, save workbooks. You can even use the same formulas online like in the client version of the program. All these applications have inbuilt Auto-correct and background spell checking. Office

Web App also encompasses Multi-user co-authoring. With all this, something very important is missing. There is no automatic synchronisation of files between the Web-based version of Office and the client version. This can potentially be very confusing; you can end up with different versions of the same document in different locations on your PC and the web and simply not know which the latest version is.

You wouldn't want to use Office Web Apps instead of a full desktop version given the choice but they'll be great when you're away from your home computer. And it is Microsoft's first direct take at Google Docs.

Final Thoughts

The big question with any new version of Microsoft Office is not "how good is it?". It is rather "Is it so much better that you should upgrade?". It appears that Microsoft has made extensive usability

improvements across the entire Office suite. This version of Office adds some very useful new features, such as Paste-Preview, a standardised Office-wide reliance on the Ribbon, Backstage View, Office Web Apps, video-editing tools in PowerPoint and much improved email handling in Outlook. Even performance wise, it seems a big improvement on Office 2003, and slightly so on Office 2007 and doesn't have significant problems. Generally, the interface feels more polished and everything more accessible. This version of Office might not wow you, but the improvements are solid. While most of the normal people can likely do without any of these latest additions, somewhere there's one of you who has been dying for each one of them. If you are still stuck on Office 2003, we would suggest you definitely want to board the train and go the Office 2010 way. For those of you using Office 2007, we would suggest to stick to it unless there's some new feature that you desperately want. **d**